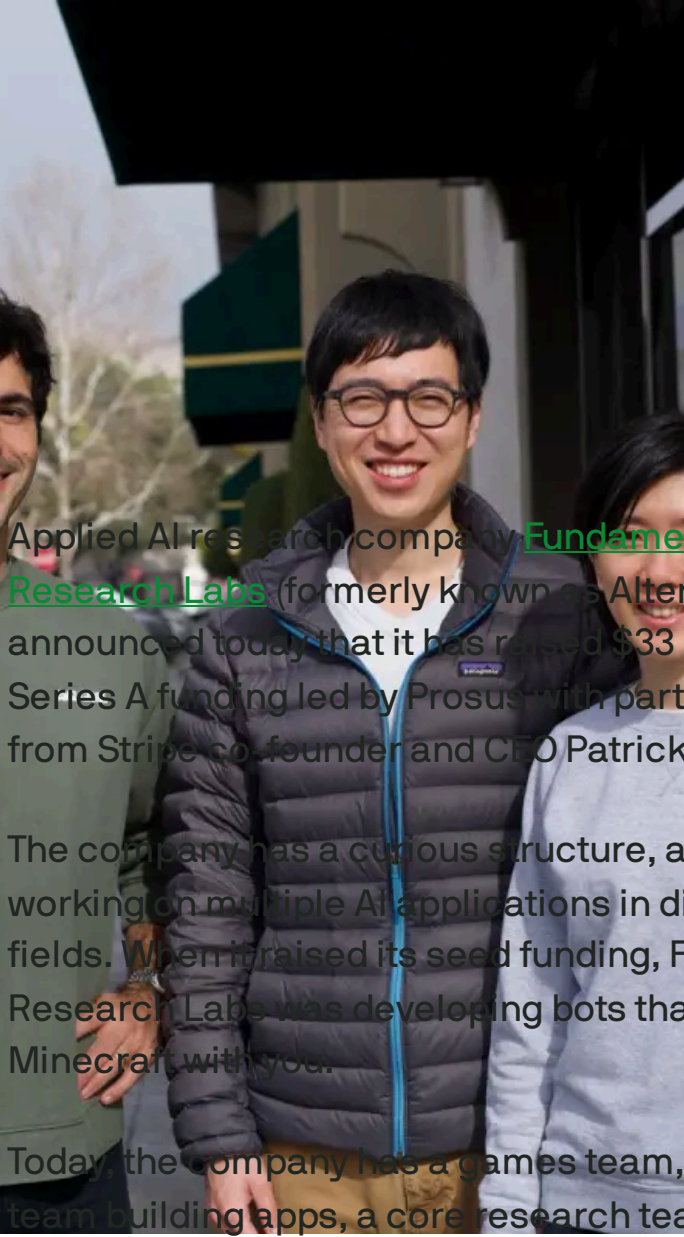


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FUNDRAISING



Fundamental Research Labs nabs \$30M+ to build AI agents across verticals



Applied AI research company [Fundamental Research Labs](#) (formerly known as Altera) announced today that it has raised \$33 million in Series A funding led by Prosus with participation from Stripe co-founder and CEO Patrick Collison.

The company has a curious structure, as it is working on multiple AI applications in different fields. When it raised its seed funding, Fundamental Research Labs was developing bots that could play Minecraft with you.

Today, the company has a games team, a prosumer team building apps, a core research team, and a platform team. The startup's founder, Dr. Robert Yang, a former faculty member at MIT, says that Fundamental Research Labs wants to be a "historical" company without adhering to a typical startup structure.

Yang said that the company is already charging users for this agent after a seven-day trial and bringing in revenue.

Among the products Fundamental Research Labs offers is a general-purpose consumer assistant called [Fairies](#). This app allows you to chat with an AI bot, connect applications, and ask questions across the knowledge bases of those applications, then ask it to schedule appointments for you on your calendar. The app can schedule workflows for you to repeatedly execute some tasks. Yang said that this app allows the startup's engineers to test out

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various capabilities of models and platform tech it is developing.

The company also offers a spreadsheet-based agent called [Shortcut](#), which has been used by analysts for creating different financial models and performing analysis over them. The startup said that this agent works like a junior analyst and can do work autonomously. The company has made it look like Excel and has tried to retain a lot of functionality for power users.

“We’ve seen many early-stage startups, but what stood out here is a small, highly mission-driven team focused on digital humans with actual use cases. Their recent launches, like Fairies and Shortcut, aren’t just demos; they’re already demonstrating how AI can augment the human workforce in meaningful ways,” Sandeep Bakshi, an investment partner at Prosus, told TechCrunch over email.

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“What stood out with Fundamental Research Labs is not just the ambition of the vision, but again the caliber of the team driving it,” he added. “Their ability to attract some of the brightest minds in the world, and turn that talent into real-world products, makes this a uniquely compelling venture opportunity for us.”

The company raised [\\$9 million in a seed round last year](#), which was co-led by First Spark Ventures and Patron, with participation from a16z Speedrun and Eric Schmidt. The startup has raised over \$40 million in funding to date.



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Yang said the company is open to trying out various application models and eventually wants to build robots as well.

“We are working on productivity (apps) now because that is where the most value is created. You can make a lot of money doing this and build your team and tech. Eventually, we want to solve physical problems and move towards working on embodiment,” Yang said.

Correction: The funding round was \$33 million, not \$30 million; the story was updated with the accurate amount.

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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Bye-bye bots: Altera's game-playing AI agents get backing from Eric Schmidt

Lauren Forristal — 8:14 AM PDT · May 8, 2024

Autonomous, AI-based players are coming to a gaming experience near you, and a new startup, [Altera](#), is joining the fray to build this new guard of AI agents.

IMAGE CREDITS: ALTERA

The company announced Wednesday that it raised \$9 million in an oversubscribed seed round, co-led by First Spark Ventures (Eric Schmidt's deep-tech fund) and Patron (the seed-stage fund co-founded by Riot Games alums).

The funding follows Altera's previous raising a pre-seed \$2 million from a16z SPEEDRUN and others in January of this year. Now, Altera wants to use the new capital to hire more scientists, engineers and team members to help with product development and growth.

If the first wave of AI for end users was about AI bots; and more recently, AI "copilots" use generative AI to help understand and respond to increasingly sophisticated queries, then AI agents are emerging as the next stage of development. The focus is on

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how AI can be used to create increasingly more human-like, nuanced entities that can respond to and interact with actual humans.

One early use case for these agents has been gaming — specifically to use in games that support modifications (mods) like Minecraft. [Voyager](#) is one recent project, built on the Minedojo framework, that creates and develops Minecraft AI agents, and this, too, is where Altera is getting its start.

The company’s first product is an AI agent that can play Minecraft with you, “just like a friend” ([the waitlist to try that out is here](#)), but this seems to be just chapter one for the company. “We are building multi-agent worlds, opening up exciting opportunities in entertainment, market research, and more,” the company promises on its site. And after that? Robot dreams, it seems.

“Creating the human qualities required to turn co-pilots into co-workers and exploring a world where digital humans are given a physical form factor,” Altera explains.

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(1/5) Altera Agents can make diamond tools from scratch in Minecraft now! Compared to the famous Voyager method, our Agents are 10-20X cheaper, more reliable, while remaining completely autonomous and Minecraft-agnostic. And you can play with them today, join our waitlist!

pic.twitter.com/IQB6Kq3vKR

— Robert Yang (@GuangyuRobert) [March 15, 2024](#)

At the helm of Altera is Robert Yang, a neuroscientist and former assistant professor at MIT. In December 2023, Yang and Altera’s other co-founders — Andrew Ahn, Nico Christie and Shuying Luo — stepped away from their applied research lab at MIT to focus on a new goal: developing AI agents (or “AI buddies,” as Yang calls them) with “social-emotional intelligence” that can interact with players and make their own decisions in-game.

“It has been my life goal as a neuroscientist to go all the way and build a digital human being — redefining what we thought AI was capable of,” Yang told TechCrunch. That is not to say that Yang is coming from a misanthropic point of view. “Our solidly pro-human framework means that we are building agents that will enhance humanity, not replace it,” he insists.

What is notable about Yang and Altera’s focus is its

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(And yes, in keeping with its consumer focus, you should not be surprised that, for now, the company is not talking about monetization at all.)



ALTERA FOUNDERS. IMAGE CREDITS: FUNDAMENTAL RESEARCH LABS

Similar to the Voyager GPT-4-powered Minecraft bot, Altera's autonomous agents are capable of playing Minecraft as if they were humans, performing tasks like building, crafting, farming, trading, mining, attacking, equipping items, chatting and moving around.

Altera's agents are designed to be companions for gamers, not assistants who do what you tell them to. Unlike NPCs (non-player characters), they have the freedom to make their own decisions, which could either make the game more entertaining or frustrating, depending on your playing style.

In a video demo, Yang plays around with multiple scenarios, including one where he tries to convince the AI agent to attack other people. The bot is hesitant at first, typing in the chat, “I don’t want any trouble, can we just find a peaceful solution? Fighting won’t solve anything.” Yang taunts it, commanding others to attack the “weak” bot. It eventually defends itself and kills Yang’s Minecraft character. “I’ll make sure they regret crossing me,” the AI agent wrote.

While the ending may be a little sinister, the gameplay feels no different from a regular session with friends, trolling and competing against each other.

Altera is currently testing the model with 750 Minecraft players and plans to officially launch later in the summer. It’ll be available via Altera’s desktop app, which is free to download but will also come with paid features.



ALTERA DEMO. IMAGE CREDITS: ALTERA

Minecraft is just a starting point for Altera. The company eventually plans to bring the model to additional video games and other digital experiences. Altera’s AI agents “execute an action as code, meaning they can play any game without material customization,” Yang explained. For instance, it could work with Stardew Valley, he said. Altera will also integrate the technology with game engine SDKs for “broader developer use.”

In addition to the recent investments by First Spark and Patron, Altera has gained support from a long list of high-profile investors, demonstrating confidence in the company’s potential. Altera boasts investors such as Alumni Ventures, a16z SPEEDRUN, Benchmark partner Mitch Lasky, Duolingo Chief Business Officer Bob Meese, Vamos Ventures, Valorant co-founder Stephen Lim and more.

“There exists a massive opportunity to create AI companions that engage in all areas of our lives. However, today’s AI lacks critical traits like empathy, embodiment, and personal goals, which prevent it from forming real, lasting connections with people,” Aaron Sisto, partner at First Spark Ventures, said in a statement. “Robert and the team at Altera are leveraging deep expertise in computational neuroscience and LLMs to build radically new types of AI agents that are fun, unique, and persistent across platforms. We are thrilled to be a part of their journey.”

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Lauren Forristal

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Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

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Alteryx acquires machine learning startup Feature Labs

Ron Miller — 7:32 AM PDT · October 4, 2019

IMAGE CREDITS: MONSITJ / GETTY IMAGES

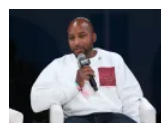
[Alteryx](#), a publicly traded analytics company, announced this morning that it has acquired [Feature Labs](#), a machine learning startup that launched [out of MIT in 2018](#). The company did not reveal the terms of the deal.

Co-founder and CEO Max Kanter told TechCrunch at the time of the launch the company had been based on research at MIT that looked at how to automate the creation of machine learning algorithms. “Feature Labs is unique because we automate feature engineering, which is the process of using

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domain knowledge to extract new variables from raw data that make machine learning algorithms work,” Kanter [told TechCrunch](#) in 2018.

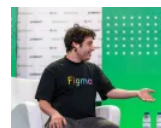
It is precisely this capability that appealed to Alteryx. “Feature Labs’ vision to help both data scientists and business analysts easily gain insight and understand the factors driving their business matches the Alteryx DNA,” Alteryx co-founder and CEO Dean Stoecker said in a statement. It’s worth noting that the company acquired another machine learning startup, Yhat, in 2017 and [launched a new feature, Alteryx Promote](#), based on that technology later that year.

[Alteryx Promote puts data science to work across the company](#)

As for Feature Labs, [writing in a blog post](#) announcing the deal, Kanter and chief data scientist Alan Jacobson saw a partner that could help it grow faster while fitting the long-term goals for the company. Kanter and Jacobson also sought to reassure its users that the mission will continue. “We plan to use this [acquisition] to expand our AI and ML efforts in both the Open Source data science community, as well as for line of business analysts that desire code-free tools that can guide them through the complex process to successfully implement AI and ML techniques with their domain knowledge,” they wrote in the post.

Feature Labs offers open-source libraries for data scientists that have been downloaded more than 350,000 times, according to the company. The company was founded in 2018 in Cambridge, Mass. and has raised \$3 million, according to Crunchbase [data](#). It will remain in Cambridge and form a new Alteryx engineering hub in the city.

STARTUPS



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Rebecca Bellan,
Theresa Loconsolo
- 14 hours ago

STARTUPS



Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the ‘agent-native economy’

Dominic-Madori Davis
- 15 hours ago

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Alteryx [went public in 2017](#) after raising more than \$160 million from VC firms like Iconiq Partners, Insight Venture Partners and Sapphire Ventures. This represents its fifth acquisition and second this year.

[Feature Labs launches out of MIT to accelerate the development of machine learning algorithms](#)

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Ron Miller

Enterprise Reporter |

Ron Miller was an enterprise reporter at TechCrunch.

Previously, he was a long-time Contributing Editor at...

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